

TIOBE PROGRAMMING COMMUNITY INDEX • MARCH 2026

TIOBE Index March 2026: How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

Ratings are calculated from skilled-engineer demand, training courses, and third-party vendors — measured via search-engine hit counts across Google, Bing, Wikipedia, Amazon, and 20+ other platforms.

For Software Engineering Leads & Technology Strategists

Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain

#	Prev	Language	Rating	YoY pp
1	1	Python	21.25%	-2.59
2	4	C	11.55%	++2.02
3	2	C++	8.18%	-2.90
4	3	Java	7.99%	-2.37
5	5	C#	6.36%	++1.49
6	6	JavaScript	3.45%	-0.01
7	9	Visual Basic	2.50%	-0.02
8	8	SQL	2.00%	-0.57
9	16	R	1.88%	++0.94
10	10	Delphi/Obj. Pascal	1.80%	-0.36
11	24	Perl	1.75%	++1.05
12	12	Scratch	1.63%	-0.03
13	11	Fortran	1.45%	-0.25
14	14	Rust	1.31%	++0.09
15	15	MATLAB	1.29%	++0.31
16	7	Go	1.29%	-1.49
17	17	Assembly	1.29%	++0.42
18	13	PHP	1.23%	-0.25
19	18	Ada	1.10%	++0.25
20	26	Swift	1.04%	++0.44

#1 Python

21.25% | YoY: -2.59 pp

Largest drop among top 5

C ↑ #4 → #2

+2.02 pp | 11.55%

Largest absolute gain in top 20

~49%

of the index held by 4 languages

Python • C • C++ • Java

pp = percentage points YoY change. Highlighted rows (green/red) = biggest rank movers. Source: TIOBE Index March 2026.

Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 – The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026

GAINERS

Perl 24 → 11 **+13 spots +1.05 pp**

Bioinformatics & infrastructure — entrenched communities

R 16 → 9 **+7 spots +0.94 pp**

Data science & statistics resurgence

Swift 26 → 20 **+6 spots +0.44 pp**

Apple platform growth; Kotlin retreats to #22

C 4 → 2 **+2 spots +2.02 pp**

Largest absolute rating gain of any language

LOSERS

Go 7 → 16 **-9 spots -1.49 pp**

Sharpest absolute drop; possible Rust displacement

C++ 2 → 3 **-1 spot -2.90 pp**

Largest percentage decline in any top-5 language

Java 3 → 4 **-1 spot -2.37 pp**

Multi-year downtrend from 25%+ peak

PHP 13 → 18 **-5 spots -0.25 pp**

Steady erosion as Python dominates web backends

Key: Go's -9-rank freefall is the steepest of any top-20 language. Legacy languages (Perl, R) defy expectations by climbing into the top 12.

From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: Four Decades of Language Rankings

Language	1986	1991	1996	2001	2006	2011	2016	2021	2026
Python	-	-	17	26	8	7	5	3	1
C	1	1	1	1	2	2	2	1	2
C++	9	2	2	2	3	3	3	4	3
Java	-	-	31	3	1	1	1	2	4
C#	-	-	-	11	7	5	4	5	5
JavaScript	-	-	33	8	10	10	8	7	6
Go	-	-	-	-	-	16	60	11	16
Ada	3	10	6	18	16	22	25	36	19
Lisp	2	4	8	19	14	13	26	34	26

Python: 0 to #1 in 25 years

Unranked before 1991. Entered top-30 by 2001. Reached #1 after 2018. A uniquely modern ascent.

Java's long decline

Dominated at 25%+ from 2005–2018. Now below 8% — the steepest fall of any top-4 language.

C: the only constant

The sole language in the top 2 across all nine measurement points from 1986 to 2026.

Lisp & Ada: four-decade fall

Lisp was #2 in 1986, now #26. Ada was #3 in 1986, now #19. Language dominance rarely persists.

Go & Ada: 2026 column shows current rank. Go was #60 in 2016, now #16. Ada re-entered top 20 at #19.

Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times — More Than Any Other Language

TIOBE "Language of the Year" — awarded to the language with the largest annual rating gain

2025

C#

2nd title in 3 years

2024

Python

6th all-time win

2023

C#

.NET ecosystem growth

2022

C++

Systems surge

2021

Python

5th all-time win

2020

Python

4th all-time win

2019

C

Steady resurgence

2018

Python

3rd all-time win

2016

Go

Preceded 2026 decline

Python: 6 wins (2007, 2010, 2018, 2020, 2021, 2024) — most of any language. C#: 2 recent wins (2023, 2025). Go won in 2016; now ranked 16th.

Note: 2017 Language of the Year winner not available in source data.

Source: TIOBE Programming Community Index, March 2026 | tiobe.com

The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index:

What This Means for Your Tech Stack

01 Python leads — but watch the trajectory

At 21.25%, Python is unchallenged. Yet its -2.59 pp YoY drop is the largest in the top 5. Hiring pipelines are safe today; re-evaluate against C's gains in 12–18 months.

02 C's resurgence signals systems / embedded growth

C gained +2.02 pp and climbed from 4th to 2nd. For teams in embedded systems, IoT, or OS-level work, C expertise is increasingly strategic.

03 Legacy languages are resilient — don't deprecate expertise

Perl (+13 ranks), R (+7 ranks), and Fortran (still top 15) serve entrenched bioinformatics, data science, and HPC communities.

04 Go's 9-rank fall demands re-assessment

Go dropped from 7th to 16th, its sharpest decline on record. Teams evaluating Go for new services should weigh this against current talent depth and Rust's rise.

05 Concentration risk: ~49% held by 4 languages

Python, C, C++, and Java dominate nearly half the index. Single-language bets amplify both upside and exposure; portfolio diversity reduces bus-factor risk.

Data: TIOBE Index March 2026 · Next update: April 2026

Combine TIOBE trends with GitHub activity, Stack Overflow surveys, and internal hiring data before making technology decisions.